

Greece Trip — July 1-10, 2026

Route: Athens → Thessaloniki → Halkidiki (Sithonia) → fly home from Thessaloniki

Travelers' brief: Fly out July 1 to ATH · Athens Jul 2-4 · Thessaloniki Jul 4-6 · Island/beach Jul 6-10

TL;DR — the recommendation

You left the last leg open ("Halkidiki or Corfu or Kefalonia or whatever"). The clear winner given your route is **Halkidiki — specifically the Sithonia peninsula**.

Why: Halkidiki is the only one you can reach **without backtracking or a connecting flight**. It's a 1.5–2.5 hr drive straight from Thessaloniki / its airport. Corfu and Kefalonia have **no direct flights from Thessaloniki** — you'd burn most of a vacation day on a connection (usually via Athens) in each direction. Since you're already in the north and ending in the north, Sithonia keeps it tight, maximizes beach time, and lets you fly home straight out of Thessaloniki (SKG).

If you specifically want the postcard "Ionian island" vibe (Kefalonia's Myrtos, Corfu's old town), see the **Alternative** at the bottom — but it costs you ~1 day of transit and you should reverse the order (island before Thessaloniki).

Flights to book

Leg	Date	Notes
Home → Athens (ATH)	Jul 1	Arrive Jul 1 (overnight transatlantic) or early Jul 2. Itinerary below assumes you land morning Jul 2 .
Athens → Thessaloniki (SKG)	Jul 4	55-min flight (Aegean/Sky Express) or 4–5 hr train (Hellenic Train) if you want the scenery. Book the flight for a morning departure.
Thessaloniki (SKG) → Home	Jul 10	Big international hub for the north. Drive Sithonia → SKG (~2 hr); leave 4 hr before an international departure.

Car: Rent in Thessaloniki on Jul 6, drop at SKG on Jul 10. A car is effectively mandatory for Sithonia beach-hopping (bus service is sparse).

Day by day



Athens — Jul 2-4 (2 nights)

Jul 2 — Arrive & the Acropolis side - Land AM, drop bags (stay in **Plaka** or **Koukaki** — walkable to everything). - Afternoon: **Acropolis** (go late, ~5pm, for softer light and smaller crowds; buy the timed ticket online in advance). Walk down through the **Acropolis Slopes** to the **Ancient Agora**. - Evening: dinner in **Plaka** or rooftop drinks with an Acropolis view (e.g., a rooftop bar in Monastiraki).

Jul 3 — Museum + neighborhoods - Morning: **Acropolis Museum** (do it after seeing the rock — it clicks better that way). - Midday: **Monastiraki** flea market → **Anafiotika** (tiny Cycladic-style village tucked under the Acropolis). - Afternoon: climb **Lycabettus Hill** (funicular option) for the citywide panorama, or chill in the **Plaka/Thissio** cafés. - Evening: dinner in **Psyrrri** or **Koukaki**. - Optional swap: If you'd rather have a beach half-day, the **Athens Riviera** (Vouliagmeni, Lake Vouliagmeni) is a 30–40 min taxi south.

Jul 4 — Fly north - Morning flight ATH → SKG. Settle into Thessaloniki by lunch.

Athens is fast-paced and hot in July — 2 nights is the right amount before you slow down up north.



Thessaloniki — Jul 4-6 (2 nights)

Greece's relaxed, food-obsessed second city. Walkable waterfront, Byzantine churches, great nightlife.

Jul 4 — Arrive & the waterfront - Check in near **Ladadika** or the **Nea Paralia** (new waterfront). - Evening stroll the **Nea Paralia promenade** to the **White Tower** (the city's landmark) at sunset. - Dinner: **Ladadika** district — start the food crawl. Thessaloniki is the food capital of Greece; lean into mezedes and tsipouro.

Jul 5 — History + market + rooftop - Morning: **Rotunda**, **Arch of Galerius (Kamara)**, and **Agios Dimitrios** church. - Midday: graze the **Modiano** and **Kapani** markets; grab a **bougatsa** (custard pastry). - Afternoon: walk up to the **Ano Poli (Upper Town)** — Ottoman-era lanes, the **Byzantine walls**, and the **Trigonion Tower** for the best sunset view over the bay. - Evening: drinks in **Valaoritou** (the city's buzziest bar quarter).

Jul 6 — Pick up car, drive to Sithonia - Collect rental car. Drive to Sithonia (~2–2.5 hr). Grab lunch en route or in **Nikiti** (gateway town).

Halkidiki / Sithonia — Jul 6-10 (4 nights)

Sithonia is the middle of Halkidiki's three "fingers" — pine forests running down to turquoise coves, far less built-up than the first finger (Kassandra). **Base yourself in Vourvourou or Nikiti** for the best access to both coasts.

Jul 6 — Settle in (West coast) - Check in, then ease into beach mode at **Trani Ammouda (Livrohio)** near Nikiti — long, shallow, calm, beach bars. Sunset on the west coast.

Jul 7 — The iconic ones - Karidi Beach (near Vourvourou) — the postcard: pines, white crescent sand, water so clear and shallow you can see the bottom 100 m out. - Afternoon: **Vourvourou** cove and beach bars.

Jul 8 — Diaporos island day (the highlight) - Rent a small **motorboat (no license required)** from Vourvourou and explore the **Diaporos** mini-archipelago — anchor in the **Blue Lagoon / Myrsini** ("the Hawaii of Greece"). Pack a picnic and snorkel gear. This is the day you'll remember.

Jul 9 — Wild east coast - Drive to the east coast: **Kavourotripes ("Orange Beach")** — sculpted white rock coves near Sarti, with **Mount Athos** rising across the water. - Lunch in **Sarti**; late afternoon back west for a final sunset. Pack tonight.

Jul 10 — Fly home - Early start: Sithonia → SKG (~2 hr) → international flight home. (Leave a generous buffer; July traffic + airport.)

Practical notes

- **July = peak season.** Pre-book the Acropolis timed ticket, both internal flights, the rental car, and Sithonia accommodation **now** — coastal stays fill fast.
- **Heat:** Athens regularly hits 35°C+. Do sights early/late, siesta midday. The north is a touch milder.
- **Money:** Cards widely accepted, but carry some cash for beach bars, tavernas, and the Diaporos boat rental.
- **Driving:** Greek motorways are tolled (cash/card). Sithonia's coastal roads are windy but fine. A car is essential there; you don't need one in Athens or central Thessaloniki.
- **Swap idea:** If you want a 5th beach night, trim Thessaloniki to 1 night — but 2 nights there is genuinely worth it for the food alone.

Alternative: classic Ionian island (Kefalonia or Corfu)

If you'd trade transit time for a true island, **reverse the trip** so the island sits next to Athens, not Thessaloniki:

Athens (Jul 2-4) → **fly to the island Jul 4-8** → fly to **Thessaloniki Jul 8-10** → home.

- **Kefalonia:** Myrtos Beach, Melissani Cave, Assos village, Fiskardo. Quieter, dramatic.
- **Corfu:** Venetian Old Town (UNESCO), Paleokastritsa, lush and green. Easiest island airport-wise.
- **Catch:** Neither has a direct flight to Thessaloniki — expect a connection (usually via Athens), so build in a half-day of transit on Jul 8. This is exactly why Sithonia is the cleaner pick for your stated route.

Sources used for logistics & beaches: - [How to get to Halkidiki from Thessaloniki — xlntransfer](#) - [Sithonia beaches guide](#) — [Thessaloniki Local](#) - [Sithonia beaches](#) — [The Wom Travel](#) - [Flights Thessaloniki → Kefalonia \(connections\)](#) — [FlightConnections](#)